

ENTRY MANAGEMENT

ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

You are asked to study the Deal and mentally devise a Plan to make the contract.

ENTRY MANAGEMENT LESSON

There may be nothing more frustrating in Bridge than looking across at dummy and seeing three good tricks sitting there - and you have no way to reach them.

Entry Management may sound classy, but it just means being in the right place at the right time.

Plan Early and Wisely:

The contract is 3NT and West leads the ♠7.

♠ A 8 3 2

♥ A J 6 4

♦ A Q 5 3

♣ A



♠ K 6

♥ 7 5 3

♦ 6 4 2

♣ K Q J 10 3

If you play low from dummy you will be forced to win your ♠K immediately, or at trick 2 after East wins trick 1 and returns another ♠.

Now you will go down because after unblocking dummy's ♣A you have no entry back to your hand.

You may have planned early, but you didn't play wisely. The contract is absolutely cold as long as you win the first trick with dummy's ♠A. Then you unblock the ♣A and you still have the ♠K entry to your hand.

Simple enough, right? Just use common sense and think **before** you play, not after.

And the good news is that most of the entry problems you encounter will be just that easy to solve.

But there are a few tougher cases, and a few strategies to get around them, which is why you decided to read this lesson.

Cheap Tricks, and when not to take them:

Bridge players realize early that it is obviously a good idea to win a trick with the smallest card that they can, thereby keeping their higher cards for later. It's hard to ignore that principle, even when you should.

Here's another 3NT contract. (Yes, Bridge writers love to use 3NT contracts.)

West leads the ♠3. East plays a low ♠.

♠ Q J 10
 ♥ 7 3
 ♦ K J 10 9 8
 ♣ 8 6 4

Suppose you let dummy's ♠10 win the trick.

When you try to establish the ♦ suit East will take the second ♦ and return a ♠.

If you play low from your hand West will take the ♠A and play another ♠ to your ♠K.

You will never reach dummy's good ♦s.

♠ K 7 5
 ♥ A Q 3 2
 ♦ Q 5
 ♣ A K 7 2

If instead you play your ♠K when East leads that second ♠ West will allow your ♠K to hold the trick.

You will never reach dummy's good ♦s.

It is easy to now see where things went wrong.

Get your ♠K out of the way by using it to win the first trick and dummy's ♠ Q J will guarantee an entry to the ♦ suit.

Unblocking intermediate cards:

Sometimes a hand looks so simple that you don't spot the danger until too late.

The contract is 6NT. West leads the ♠6.

East takes the ♠A and returns the ♠J.

♠ 5 3 2
 ♥ 6 2
 ♦ 8 5 4
 ♣ A K Q 5 3

This looks like a cinch as long as the ♣s don't split 4-0.

You win the second trick with your ♠K, play the ♣4 to dummy's ♣Q, and breathe a sigh of relief when both defenders follow suit (it turns out they split 3-1).

♠ K 7 4
 ♥ A K Q
 ♦ A K Q
 ♣ 8 7 6 4

A few minutes later that sigh of relief turns into a cry of anguish when you discover that you can only win 4 ♣ tricks because after taking ♣ A K Q you will take the next ♣ in your hand!

Try it again from trick 2. This time play the ♣8 to dummy's ♣Q, and play the ♣7 and ♣6 under the ♣K and ♣A. Then, when you play dummy's ♣5 you can slip your ♣4 underneath it!

Overtaking to save an entry:

There is another way the sacrifice of a high card may pay off as an entry.

The contract is 3NT. West leads the ♠Q.

♠ 6
 ♥ 8 4 3
 ♦ A Q 10 9 8 7
 ♣ K 5



♠ A K 4 2
 ♥ A 7 6 2
 ♦ K
 ♣ A 8 6 4

Outside the ♦ suit you have 5 winners and no chance of creating any more.

So you need to get at least 4 ♦ tricks.

Suppose you win the first trick, play your ♦K, then go to dummy with the ♣K and start running the ♦s. All will be well if they split 3-3 but a 4-2 split is more likely with one defender holding ♦ J x x x.

Now try it this way. Win the first trick, play your ♦K, **OVERTAKE IT WITH THE ♦A**, then continue with ♦Q, ♦10. Somebody will win their ♦J but you still have that precious ♣K dummy entry to those other good ♦s.

The ♦K was worth more as an entry than it was as a high card.

Finessing for an entry:

That title doesn't sound like much of a daring strategy - of course there are times when you will have to finesse to get the entry you need.

Ahh, but here we are talking about a finesse that would otherwise be completely unnecessary, one which, if it loses, will actually throw a sure trick away.

The contract is 6♣. West leads the ♥Q.

♠ K Q 9 7 6 3
 ♥ 6 4 2
 ♦ A J
 ♣ 4 2



♠ --
 ♥ A K 5 3
 ♦ K 8
 ♣ A K Q J 9 8 7

You have 2 ♥ losers. A 3-3 split in the suit would allow you to set up your fourth ♥ but West's opening lead makes you think he probably has 4 or 5 ♥s.

You decide you must establish some ♠ tricks in dummy, but you need two entries for that play, one to get over there the first time and the second to get back after you have dislodged their ♠A. Unfortunately you have only one sure entry, the ♦A.

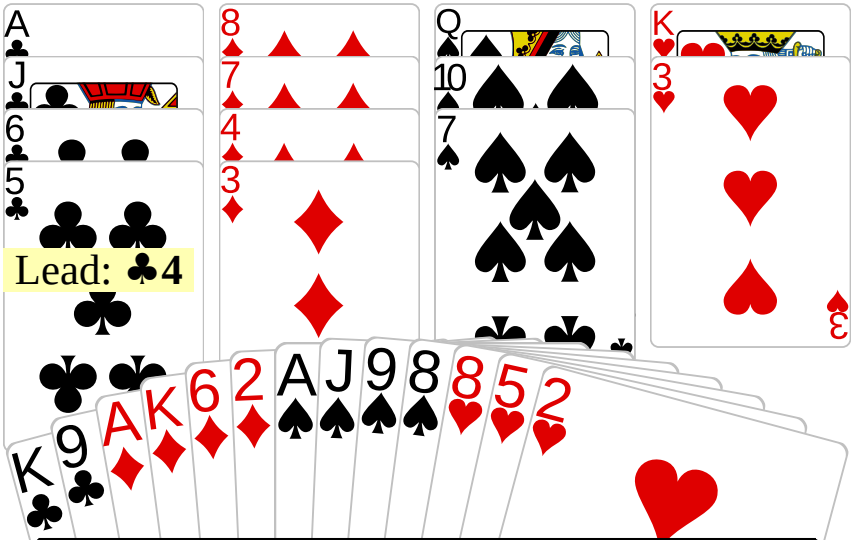
Win the first trick. Pull trumps in 2 or 3 rounds. Play a small ♦ and when West plays low finesse the ♦J - the unnecessary finesse. Today it wins. Now play the ♠K and when East plays a low card discard a ♥ loser. West can win the ♠A but you win his return, enter dummy with the ♦A and discard your other ♥ loser on the ♠Q.

Now ask yourself this: How good would West have to be to put his ♦Q on your first ♦ play to deprive you of that entry? Pretty good, I'd say.

There are other scenarios, many involving the sacrifice of a winner to gain an entry, and while we could go on and on and on . . .

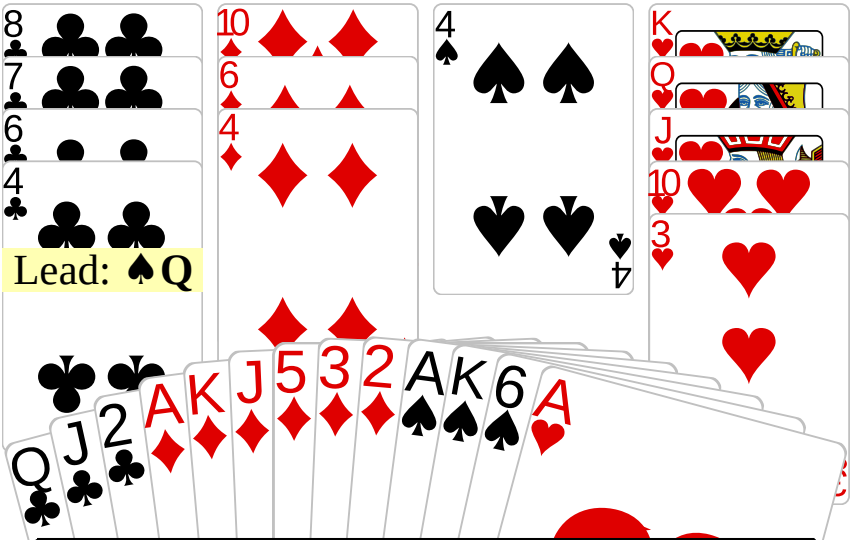
. . . 20 examples should be worth more than another 2000 words.

Deal 1 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners



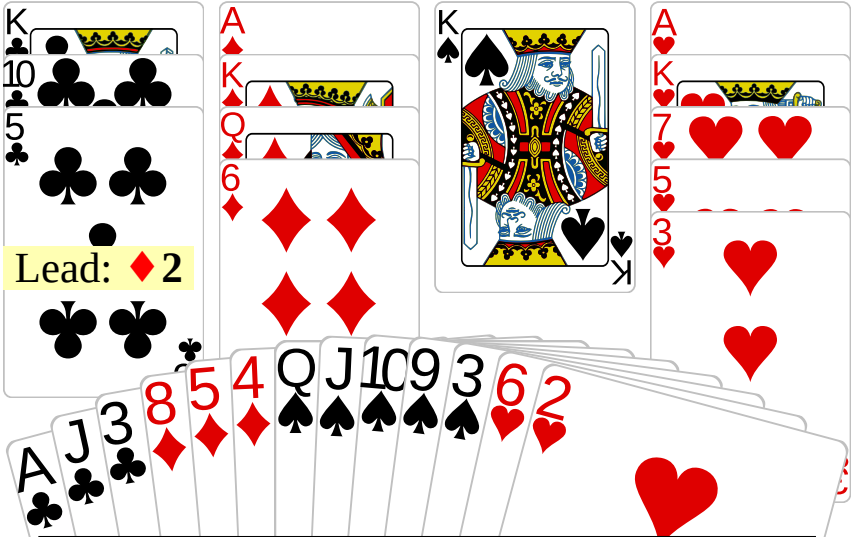
Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 2 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners



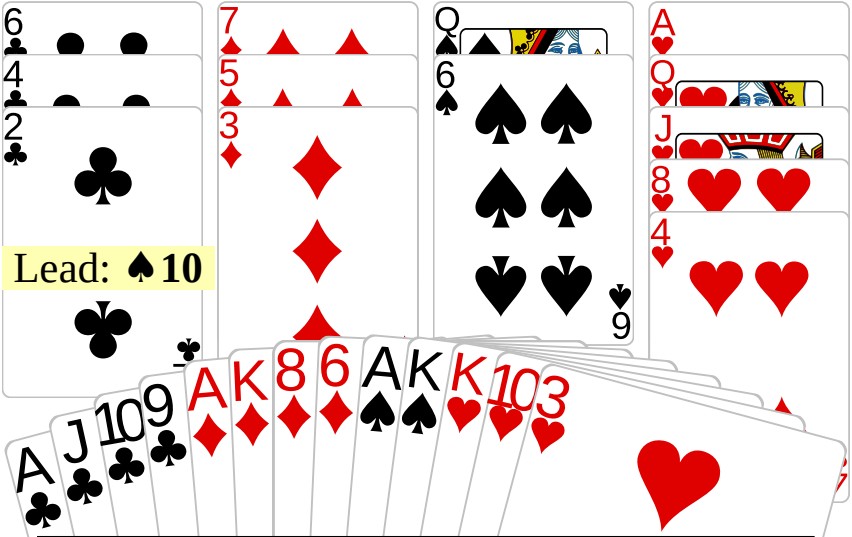
Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 3 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners



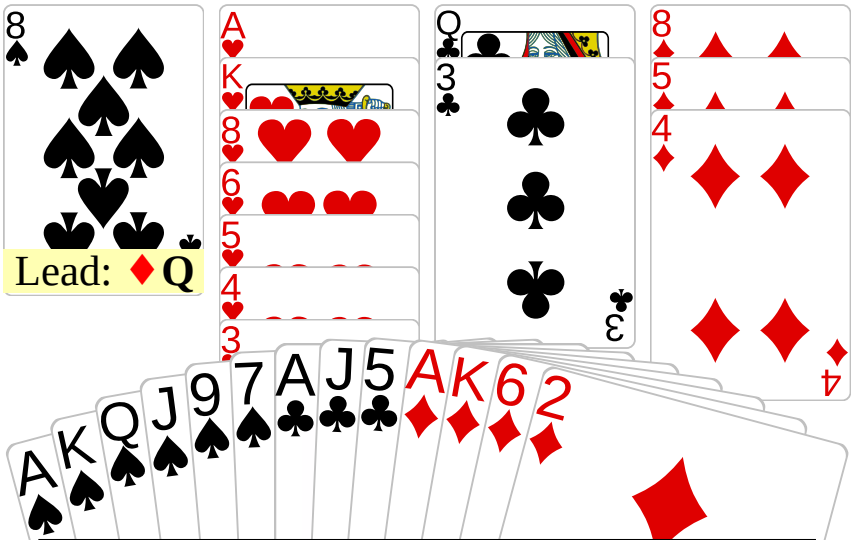
Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 4 Ctr: 6NT Goal: at least ____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 5 Ctr: 6♠ Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Board: 1

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: North

Lead: ♣4

Board: 2

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: East

Lead: ♠Q

Board: 3

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: South

Lead: ♦2

Board: 4

Dealer: **West**

Contract: 6NT

Declarer: West

Lead: ♠10

Board: 5

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6♠

Declarer: North

Lead: ♦Q

Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ K 5 3 2
 ♥ A Q J 10
 ♦ J 10
 ♣ 7 3 2

♠ A J 9 8

♥ 8 5 2

♦ A K 6 2

♣ K 9

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 6 4

♥ 9 7 6 4

♦ Q 9 5

♣ Q 10 8 4

♠ Q 10 7

♥ K 3

♦ 8 7 4 3

♣ A J 6 5

West

North

East

South

1NT

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by North

Lead: ♣4

and finessing the ♣J! You are pretty sure East has led from the ♣Q so you expect this to work.

West plays low.

Lead the ♠10 (or ♠Q) and underplay it with your ♠8 (or ♠9), so you stay in dummy. You had better cash the ♣A next, then the ♠Q, letting it ride if not covered. Finally, one last ♠ finesse gives you 4 ♠ winners.

This is another twist on the them of winning with a higher card than necessary.

Here it doesn't actually create an extra entry, it just preserves the one entry you have but saves you an actual trick.

Here is an interesting point. Suppose that East's opening lead had been a ♥ and West had taken the first four ♥ tricks then played a ♦. You would have played the hand the same way! Take the ♣K, then finesse the ♣J.

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♣4, you play dummy's ♣5 and West plays the ♣7.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=0 ♦=2 ♣=3 Total = 6

You'd really like to find 3 winners without broaching that ♥ suit, so you decide to pin your hopes on the ♠ finesse. But you have a problem. When you win the first trick with the ♣9 your only safe entry to dummy is by leading your ♣K to the ♣A. And this uses up one of your ♣ winners! Do you see a way to avoid the problem?

Don't win the first trick with the ♣9, win with the ♣K.

East plays low.

At trick two you enter dummy by playing your ♣9

Board 2

East Deals

N-S Vul

♠ 4

♥ K Q J 10 3

♦ 10 6 4

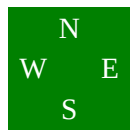
♣ 8 7 6 4

♠ 8 5 3

♥ 8 6 5 2

♦ Q 9 7

♣ A 10 5



♠ A K 6

♥ A

♦ A K J 5 3 2

♣ Q J 2

♠ Q J 10 9 7 2

♥ 9 7 4

♦ 8

♣ K 9 3

West

North

East

South

2♦

Pass

3♦

Pass

3♥

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by East

Lead: ♠Q

your ♦ A K and you will get all 6 ♦ tricks.

The biggest problem with this great play is that North probably doesn't know for sure what you are doing to him.

Maybe after the hand is over he will appreciate it more and congratulate you.

East is to play 3NT. South leads the ♠Q, dummy plays the ♠4 and North the ♠3.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=1 ♦=2 ♣=0 Total = 5

There they are, four perfectly good ♥ tricks and no straightforward way to reach them. On the other hand, (I should say "In the other hand"), you have the possibility of 6 ♦ tricks, if the ♦Q drops, in which case you won't need the ♥ tricks at all. Can you work those two possibilities into a strategy?

Sure. The ♦ problem is that the outstanding ♦s may split 3-1 with one defender holding ♦ Q x x. So it would appear you could only get 5 ♦ winners. But you can thwart him like this.

Win the ♠. Unblock the ♥A. Now play the ♦J. If Mr. ♦ Q x x takes this trick dummy's ♦10 will become an entry to those wonderful ♥s. But if he cleverly refuses to win the ♦Q, then it will fall under

Board 3

North Deals

None Vul

♠ 8 7 5 4

♥ 10 8

♦ J 9 7 2

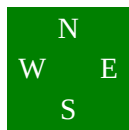
♣ Q 8 4

♠ K

♥ A K 7 5 3

♦ A K Q 6

♣ K 10 5



♠ A 6 2

♥ Q J 9 4

♦ 10 3

♣ 9 7 6 2

♠ Q J 10 9 3

♥ 6 2

♦ 8 5 4

♣ A J 3

West

North

East

South

2 ♣

Pass

2 ♠

Pass

3 ♥

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by South

Lead: ♦ 2

may win even more. Just watch.

Win the opening ♦ lead in dummy. Play the ♠ K which the defenders are not about to take while you have a ♣ entry to your hand. Now play the ♣ 10 and pass it to West. If West takes the ♣ Q then you will have TWO entries to your hand, one to get there for a ♠ lead, and the other to reach the ♠ winners after you have driven out the ♠ A. But if West DOESN'T take the ♣ Q, or if East actually has it, then you will have 3 ♣ tricks and your contract.

Isn't it nice to have a finesse that wins if it wins but also wins if it loses?

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♦ 2.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=3 ♣=2 Total = 8

The reason the Winners list shows 1 ♠ is that the defenders are going to have to let you win dummy's ♠ K. If they take that then you'll have 4 ♠ winners in your hand!

So you only need one more winner really, and if you guess the ♣ finesse right you will have it. Which way will you finesse, and why?

You win the ♦ in dummy and play the ♠ K, which the defenders let hold.

East plays low.

You will finesse through East. If he has the ♣ Q you will win all 3 ♣ tricks, but if West has the ♣ Q you

Board 4

West Deals

Both Vul

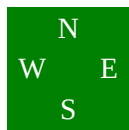
♠ A K
 ♥ K 10 3
 ♦ A K 8 6
 ♣ A J 10 9

♠ 10 9 8 5 2

♥ 9 7 5 2

♦ J 4

♣ K 5



♠ Q 6
 ♥ A Q J 8 4
 ♦ 7 5 3
 ♣ 6 4 2

♠ J 7 4 3

♥ 6

♦ Q 10 9 2

♣ Q 8 7 3

West	North	East	South
2♣	Pass	2♥	Pass
2NT	Pass	6NT	
All Pass			

6NT by West

Lead: ♠ 10

West is to play 6NT. North leads the ♠ 10, dummy plays the ♠ 6 and South the ♠ 3.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=5 ♦=2 ♣=1 Total = 10

You need two more winners and the best bet is to try to pick up three ♣ tricks. You will need the ♣K and ♣Q to lie in different hands, or both of them to be with South. That is about a 75% chance.

But you may need to make 3 finesses, so that means 3 entries to dummy, all of which must be in the ♥ suit. Can it be done?

You win the ♠ lead in your hand, then lead the ♥K and North plays low.

South follows with the ♥6.

South plays low.

Of course it can. Win the ♠ lead in your hand and play the ♥K, overtaking with dummy's ♥A. Now play a ♣ to your ♣9, which loses to North's ♣K. North plays another ♠.

Now play the ♥10, and when North follows you are safe to overtake with dummy's ♥J since you can tell that South did not start with 4 ♥s. In fact, South shows out so it is North who started with 4 ♥s but that won't be a problem for you. Play another ♣ from dummy, finessing the ♣10 which wins.

Now play your ♥3 toward dummy, finessing the ♥8 when North follows with a low card. Play dummy's two ♥ winners, discarding ♦s, then the low ♣ to your ♣J. Wow.

The making of a Plan is a very important step in being a good Declarer.

And as you have figured by now, assessing how many entries you are going to need is big part of that plan. Like here, if you had won a single ♥ trick in your hand then you wouldn't have had the three entries to dummy.

Board 5

North Deals

N-S Vul

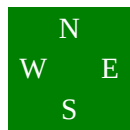
♠ 6 5 3 2
 ♥ Q 10 7
 ♦ 9 7
 ♣ K 9 7 4

♠ A K Q J 9 7

♥ —

♦ A K 6 2

♣ A J 5



♠ 10 4

♥ J 9 2

♦ Q J 10 3

♣ 10 8 6 2

♠ 8

♥ A K 8 6 5 4 3

♦ 8 5 4

♣ Q 3

West	North	East	South
	2♣	Pass	2♥
Pass	2♠	Pass	3♥
Pass	6♠		
All Pass			

6♠ by North

Lead: ♦ Q

then you have a dummy entry in the form of the ♣Q. If they refuse to take the trick you will counter by next laying down the ♣A, then ruffing a third ♣ to get to dummy and the two golden eggs.

The first time I ever saw this type of play in a book I fell in love with it.

My dream is that someday I will get a chance to use it at the table. If you ever do be sure and email me.

Pretty bold bidding by North, but partner DID make a positive response. North is to play 6♠. East leads the ♦Q, dummy plays the ♦4 and West the ♦7.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=0 ♦=2 ♣=1 Total = 3

OK, the plan is to get over to dummy for those two ♥ winners.

If you just play a small ♣ toward the ♣Q that will work whenever East holds the ♣K.

How about playing ♣A an a small ♣, planning on ruffing your third ♣ to get to dummy? Naaah. They will win the second ♣ and play a trump.

There is actually a play that is 100% certain, no matter who holds the ♣K.

Win the opening lead and lay down your ♣J. The defense is helpless. If they take the ♣J with the ♣K,